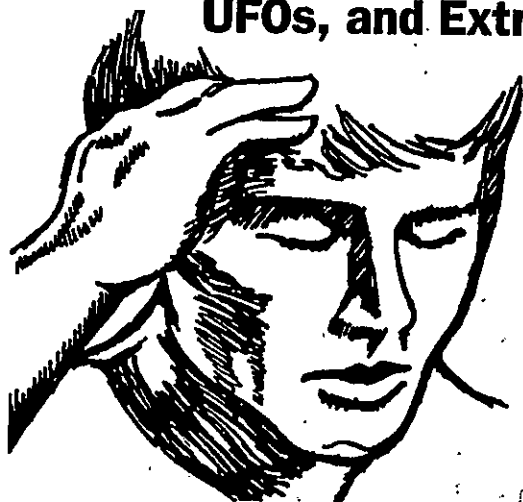


FATE Sept. 1993

On Remote-Viewing, UFOs, and Extraterrestrials



by Ingo Swann

A new controversy

During the last year or so, the UFO community has found itself not only possessed of its usual problems (such as confirming that UFOs exist), but also by a new situation convulsing the community's gossip networks.

A growing number of people are claiming to use their *remote-viewing* powers to penetrate UFOs and extraterrestrial motives, goals, and civilizations. Remote-viewing is apparently being thought of as a new, better psychic ability that certain Earthside individuals claim to have achieved, and advertise that with it they are achieving novel, intimate, and true "viewings" (i.e., sightings)

into Spaceside ET affairs.

Many long-term FATE readers probably remember the emergence in parapsychology of remote-viewing in 1973-74, and FATE editors have kept abreast of its developments by publishing occasional articles. A list of references is provided at the end of this essay for those who wish to know more about the remote-viewing story.

This new controversy (perhaps only a transient brouhaha) has come about because UFO investigators never before permitted mixing their work with psychic "stuff," while parapsychologists never mixed their work with UFO "stuff." And so mixing these two "stuffs" is stirring

up complaints, critical objections, and worries in both communities.

This new confusion is added to the other confusing imbroglios that characterize the UFO "situation" (governmental-military cover-ups, irresponsible scientific debunking, and UFO-community leadership disputes).

I've been intimately involved in remote-viewing developments for over 20 years. Many people send me alleged ET "remote-viewing" reports, and seek me out to ask what I think about this new situation—including the editors of FATE, who have asked me to say something about it.

Remote-viewing's key element: utilitarian value

All of our lives are shaped by discovering the utilitarian value, not only of things but of ourselves. Remote-viewing is no exception to this. And so this new brouhaha hinges on whether there is any real utilitarian value in attempting to "utilize remote-viewing to penetrate UFOs and/or ETs."

But to determine the utilitarian value of something one has to be sure that one has a well-defined specimen of it in hand, and then subject it to rigorous testing that positively demonstrates any utilitarian value.

Along this line of thinking, it is worth wondering how many of those claiming to remote-view ETs both-

ered to look up remote-viewing's definition in the parapsychological literature. If they had, then they might have thought twice about claiming to be remote-viewers.

I cannot, of course, control how people seek to use terms in the ways they do. Meanings shift about, and many use terms in different flip-flop ways even if clearly defined in dictionaries.

For example, take the word "sophisticated." It is derived from the Sophist philosophical school of ancient Greece. Sophists had a habit of muddling up their thinking, especially by arguments that were later proven to be fallacious. So a sophister, as defined in the 1828 Webster's dictionary, is "A disputant fallaciously subtle, an artful but insidious logician," i.e. a muddled thinker disguised as artful and logical. Most skeptics and not a few alleged psychics ultimately were proven to have been sophisters.

The 1828 Webster's dictionary defines sophisticated as to adulterate, to corrupt by something spurious or foreign, to pervert. But today the term is generally taken to mean something perfectly achieved, elegant and balanced when referring to a thing, elegant and world-wise and knowing when referring to a person. The shift in meaning came about in the 1920s when intellectuals then took pride in being artfully and elegantly insidious, and when young Hollywood

needed a buzzword to describe the handsome and beautiful exteriors of their prized movie stars.

I will show ahead that anyone claiming to be a remote-viewer, or claiming to remote-view ETs and UFOs is a sophister, one who has artfully but insidiously muddled up the established definition of remote-viewing—perhaps only because they haven't bothered to look it up. A sophister—unless one important facet of their "remote-viewing" is undertaken by them or ultimately provided by others.

The origin of the term "remote-viewing"

I can speak this way about the term remote-viewing because it was coined, in 1971–72, by myself and Dr. Janet Mitchell, at the American Society for Psychical Research (ASPR) in New York, in association with Dr. Gertrude Schmeidler and Dr. Karlis Osis. It was coined to identify a particular kind of experiment—not a particular kind of psi ability.

There is a substantial definitional difference between coining a term to identify a type of ESP experiment and an ESP ability. It is very difficult to define a psychic ability. But it is not hard to define an experiment.

Experiments have what in science are called "protocols," more simply put as "steps" that govern

how the experiment is conducted. The last step in any experimental protocol involves determining whether the experiment worked or not. Finding out if the experiment worked or not, or how well it worked, is called "confirmation," but usually more intimately spoken of as "feedback." Without feedback in some form, it cannot be known if the experiment worked. Positive feedback suggests possible utilitarian value; negative feedback, or absence of it, does not.

Without feedback in
some kind of form it
cannot be known if the
experiment worked.

Different kinds of experiments need to be distinguished from one another, and so researchers settle on some easy-to-remember nomenclature or acronym that best describes what the experiment involves. Sometimes these experiment-terms can be pretty silly, but even so they sometimes catch on as popular buzz words beyond the scope of identifying a particular type of experiment.

In the case of the term "remote-viewing," there can be no doubt at

all that it originally referred to an experimental model (never to a novel ESP ability), and there exists a voluminous and dated paper trail, the whole of which constitutes an enormous archive. A vast number of official research documents contain adequate descriptions of the original intended meaning of remote-viewing. And this meaning is also found adequately displayed and demonstrated in a number of earlier popular books (see bibliography).

In late 1970, by a strange set of circumstances, I was invited by Dr. Karlis Osis and Dr. Gertrude Schmeidler to act as an experimental subject in certain ongoing experiments at the American Society of Psychical Research in New York. Dr. Osis was then the Society's research director, and had taken a deep interest in out-of-body experiences (OBE) that in earlier decades had been referred to by such confusing terms as traveling clairvoyance, ecsomatic experiences, bilocation, and astral projection.

Dr. Osis and colleagues were recruiting volunteers to "test" for OBE abilities via an experimental model involving a tray suspended just beneath a room's ceiling. Hanging suspended on the trays just below the ceiling, out of the subjects' sight, various objects (the targets) had been placed. The experimental goal was to ask the subjects to try to "go out of body," float up to above the trays, and then "look down and

see" what was concealed on them.

The OBE experiment involved an assumption: that if the subjects correctly identified the hidden objects then they had "gone out of their bodies" in order to do so. And so this model was called an OBE experiment.

In any event, I went to the ASPR two or three days a week for many months and tried to identify an endless series of targets—while strapped into a chair with my brain waves being monitored on an EEG machine by Janet Mitchell. At first I was not very good at this kind of "perceiving," but as the months wore on, I got better at it.

Regardless of the ambiguous assumption, the experiments were very careful ones. A target was hidden from the subject, who was to try to perceive it. After the subject verbally reported his or her "seeing," the report was compared to the object (judged) in full view of everyone, and in this way feedback was achieved as to accuracy or not.

One winter day in November 1972, I was having trouble "floating up" to the hidden targets in the windowless experimental room, but happened to "notice through the walls" that a woman in a dreadful orange coat was walking down the sidewalk past the ASPR building. I first discounted this, but suddenly tore off the electrodes and got Janet Mitchell to run into the street with me to see if a woman in an orange



coat was walking by the building. We tumbled down the stairs and got outside just in time to see a woman in an orange coat turning the corner.

This event was not part of the official OBE experiment, but it got me to thinking about why I should have "seen" the woman outside when the targets were inside.

Now, a subtle point needs to be made. The official experiment required that the subject "see" the specified targets. In other words the experiment was target-focused—and not "seeing" focused. If the subject did not see the targets, then the experiment was considered a failure—all of which seems sensible enough in a standard kind of way and in fact, is the only way that feedback can be achieved for any

kind of ESP test-experiment, including those associated with remote-viewing.

But there is a significant difference between (1) the "seeing" of the designated targets and (2) the dimensions or scope the "seeing" itself. Yet, as I was soon to discover, all parapsychology experiments were entirely of the see-the-target-only kind, and hardly any research had ever gone into the "seeing" processes and their dimensions.

It was at about this point that my see-the-target efforts, intermittently successful thereto, fell victim to the utter boredom of doing hundreds and hundreds of attempts, often 30 or more in a given afternoon. To help alleviate the boredom, I suggested that we spend a little time

"playing around" with the "seeing" processes themselves. The orange-coated woman event had suggested that "seeing" might have greater "distance capabilities" than merely from the floor to the ceiling or into the next room.

Janet Mitchell and I devised a playing-around experiment in which I would try to "see" the weather conditions in distant cities. Since some kind of feedback was absolutely necessary to determine what was "seen," after my distant weather impressions had been given and recorded, Janet or someone else could immediately telephone the weather information number in the distant city and find out what the weather was doing. The cities we were to play around with "seeing" were selected by third parties. So unless I had somehow memorized all the weather conditions in a large number of cities, it was reasonable to conclude that a "distant seeing" had taken place if the response was fed back as correct.

According to my dated and carefully preserved archives, the first long-distance "seeings" of this kind took place on the afternoon of December 8, 1971, and the first results were encouraging. But more, the processes of this kind of "seeing" was exciting and invigorating, and with this entertainment option available, my boredom alleviated and the local target experiments resumed vigorously with results that

were inexplicably better.

It was at this point that the problem of what to call the long-distance experiments emerged in order to distinguish between them and the local target experiments inside the ASPR building. We first thought of them as "traveling clairvoyance" experiments; but since this named an ability, not an experiment, I suggested that we call them "remote-sensing" experiments because after all, the distant cities, such as Tucson and Denver, were remote from the ASPR in New York. Shortly, though, it became clear that I didn't just sense the sites, but experienced mental-image pictures of them in a visualizing kind of way.

Without at all thinking much about it, and before the end of 1971, we began referring to the long-distance experiments as remote-viewing ones, since this term seemed the most suitable.

Since the psi-perceptual-processes that might account for the "seeing" were a mystery, it is again to be understood that the term remote-viewing did not refer to them, or to any novel ESP ability. From the start-up of its usage, remote-viewing referred to the entire experimental model, and the experiment was one only because of the feedback that could be supplied by telephoning the distant weather agency.

In fact and in deed without the feedback, one cannot tell whether any verifiable "seeing" had taken

On Remote-Viewing

place or not, cannot tell how good or bad it was, or how efficient or inefficient it was, or whether the "viewing" was merely the result of fantasy, imagination, opinion, or wishful thinking.

It was at this point (in early 1972), after thinking these matters through, that I got the three ideas (rather simple ones) that psi researchers have either missed or completely avoided:

1. Psi perceptions plus feedback=remote-viewing;
2. Remote-viewing minus feedback=?

Well, remote-viewing minus feedback actually equals whatever you do or do not want it to. For example, it can represent illusion to skeptics, who do not bother to study feedback even if it is available. It can represent wishful thinking to would-be psychics who do not bother to demonstrate feedback especially if it cannot be available in the first place.

These considerations led to the third rather simple idea:

3. That feedback is more important than the psi perceptions, because without it the former cannot be said either to exist or have occurred, or to what degree of accuracy. Thus, beyond any and all doubt, feedback has a great deal to do with establishing utilitarian value of psi perceptions whether they are called ESP, clairvoyance, or whatever.

Feedback, then, is not trivial or incidental to the remote-viewing process and protocols. It is *crucial* to them.

To simplify all this, we can resort to a easy-to-understand formula. Remote-viewing consists of five absolutely necessary ingredients: (1) subject, (2) active ESP abilities, (3) distant target, (4) subject's recorded responses, (5) confirmatory positive feedback—all of which equals, (6) the remote-viewing model.

Nothing less is remote-viewing.

Those alleging themselves to be remote-viewers, then, cannot simply just "remote-view," but are obliged also to show positive evidence of their "viewings"—e.g. positive feedback. Without the feedback, such "viewers" are merely offering unsupported accounts that may or may not be of psychic origin. Remote-viewing is neither a novel psi ability, nor a convenient replacement term for psi, clairvoyance, or ESP.

Objections to muddling-up: The definition of remote-viewing

I am particularly heartless regarding this matter, and for the following explicit reasons. What remote-viewing does represent, in its complete protocol, was gained by two decades of untold hours of work and excruciatingly detailed research on the parts of hundreds of people, including myself.

It was gained at a cost of much money provided by hundreds of ad-

ditional people who had experimental interest in ascertaining remote-viewing's utilitarian value, and in identifying and understanding its psychic-dynamic processes.

Its existence as a verifiable topic for experimental research was established against hundreds of fearsome debunking attacks emanating from organized police-like sophister-skeptics bent on enforcing the scientific orthodoxy that psi is non-existent, and that claims for it are of illusory or psychopathological origin.

As a result of all these efforts, the term remote-viewing entered the language with something akin to scientific merit and it is this merit that a variety of individuals are now trying to colonize in attempts to imply merit for their self-styled psychic espionage attempts regarding UFOs and ETs.

If even one individual alleges himself or herself to be a remote-viewer (sic) without showing how concrete positive feedback of their "viewing" can be realized, well, these people are playing into the drooling minds of sophister-skeptics just waiting to debunk not only them, but remote-viewing itself, and, as well, creative ufological and parapsychological interest in its utilitarian value.

This value has yet to be proven, and it can only be proven by positive feedback. So, kids out there, where's your feedback to substantiate your "remote-viewings?"

The remote-viewing-ET feedback problem

I'm not at all saying that psychic perceptions cannot be applied to the ET-UFO situation. I've openly suggested this potential data-source myself. But if psychic data is derived via many people wanting to contribute it, still the hard issue of feedback is a crucial determinant regarding what to make of that data.

Some parapsychologists have referred to their work as the "Illusive Science." Well, the illusiveness of UFOs and ETs far surpasses even that terribly illusive science. So illusive, indeed, that ufologists as a group are unable to agree upon even just one UFO or ET fact—while parapsychologists as a group at least agree that psi exists.

If parapsychology is the illusive science, then clearly ufology is virtually the "Feedbackless Science"—with the true exception so far of the hundreds of camcorders that have filmed UFOs. To my knowledge, UFOs and ETs do not cooperate with humans regarding our efforts to substantiate anything about them.

Psychically contributing either possibly real or possibly imaginary data about ETs is one matter, usually only a confusing one. But realizing feedback on even one part of that data is an entirely different matter. And it is a matter in which everyone should take a creative interest.

Of what, then, would feedback on UFO-ET matters consist? Here

is the principle problem of ufology as a whole—and it is the principle problem also of any attempts to incorporate remote-viewing protocols into ufology.

Summing up

Remote-viewing is composed of a five-part protocol, and when any one of the five parts are omitted (such as confirmatory feedback), then what has taken place is something else other than remote-viewing. The history of the origin and developments of remote-viewing are easily available, and its exact definition is found in several books, documents, and in other sources. Its definition is clearly given in *The Encyclopedia of Parapsychology and Psychical Research* (1991), compiled by Arthur S. Berger and Joyce Berger (although those compilers do not correctly attribute its origin, probably because of the lack of historical data.)

To quote that Encyclopedia: "Remote-Viewing: A protocol to test for extrasensory perception." (Emphasis added.)

"Testing for" extrasensory perception requires feedback, and as such is the key element regarding remote-viewing. Without feedback confirmations only unconfirmed psi perceptions have taken place, and should be openly and fairly presented as such. It is not ethical to try to lead others into believing that psi perception has taken place until it

can be confirmed by appropriate feedback that it has.

I fully believe that many people have correct psychic intuition, feelings, or even hunches concerning UFOs and ETs. I certainly have some of my own, and it is desirable to encourage the wider publication of them—but only as such. If these important definitional boundaries are not understood and maintained, the ultimate result will be an ambiguous definitional quagmire of benefit to no one, and the demolition of what the remote-viewing protocol achieved in terms of respect and repute.

I do not excuse myself from this sensible, and ethical, mandate. Since 1971, I've participated in well over a million remote-viewing exercises, and rigorously dissected its psi-perceptual processes. But I've never said I was a "remote-viewer," or claimed to use "remote-viewing" as an ability. Remote-viewing is a format, and only the feedback of each separate remote-viewing exercise establishes whether or not remote-viewing has taken place.

In a very literal sense, then, it is the positive feedback that is remote-viewing. Without the former the latter cannot be said to exist, and clearly no utilitarian value of it can be perceived.

References

Note: Regarding the following references, while remote-viewing

was originally conceived at the ASPR in 1971, it received international merit after 1974 at Stanford Research Institute (SRI) under the auspices of Dr. H.E. Puthoff and Mr. Russell Targ, along with many other contributors with whom I worked for 18 years, and to whom I'm deeply indebted both in fact and memory.

Additionally, the remote-viewing protocol was successfully demonstrated by other research groups. I've listed the following references chronologically, since the chronology takes precedence over the authors in that it shows the increasing involvement of remote-viewing with various kinds of wider interests. The full history of the development of remote-viewing has yet to be written, but is under way by myself.

Swann, Ingo. *To Kiss Earth Good-Bye*. New York: Hawthorn Books, 1975. Republished: New York: Dell Publishing Co., 1977.

Wilhelm, John L. *The Search for Superman*. New York: Pocket Books, 1976. Also, *Psychic Spying? Outlook/Washington Post Sunday Magazine*, August 7, 1977.

Puthoff, Harold E. and Russell Targ. *Mind-Reach: Scientists Look at Psychic Ability*. Delacorte Press/Eleanor Friede, 1977.

Swann, Ingo. *Natural ESP: The*

ESP Core and Its Raw Characteristics. New York: Bantam Books, 1987. Republished: Los Angeles: Jeremy P. Tarcher, Inc., 1991. (Note: This is the only published book discussing and illustrating the most important psychic-mind-dynamic phenomena and problems of the remote-viewing process.)

Mitchell, Janet Lee. *Out-of-Body Experiences: A Handbook*. London: McFarland & Company, 1981.

Ebon, Martin. *Psychic Warfare: Threat or Illusion?* New York: McGraw-Hill Book Co., 1983.

Gittelsohn, Bernard. *Intangible Evidence*. New York: Simon & Schuster, 1987.

Jahn, Robert G. and Brenda J. Dunne. *Margins of Reality*. New York: Harcourt Brace Jovanovich, 1987.

Mitchell, Janet Lee. *Conscious Evolution*. New York: Ballantine, 1989.

Blum, Howard. *Out There: The Government's Secret Quest for Extraterrestrials*. New York: Simon & Schuster, 1990.

Alexander, John B., Richard Groller, and Janet Morris. *The Warrior's Edge*. New York: William Morrow and Company, 1990. ■